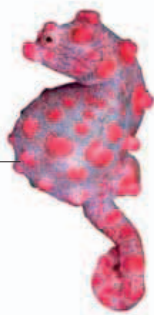


swollen belly of
pregnant male

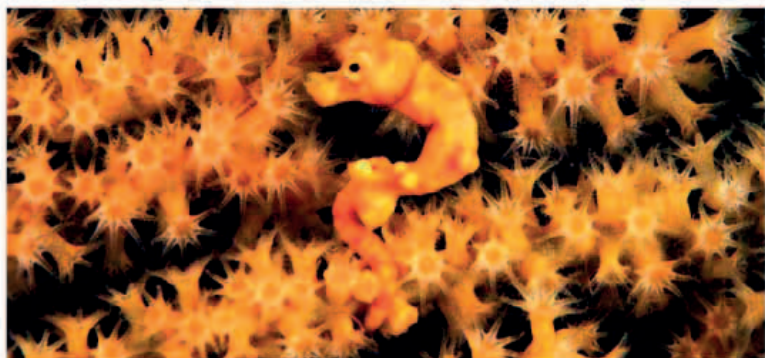


Bargibant's pygmy seahorse

Hippocampus bargibanti

Found on coral reefs at depths of 53–130 ft (16–40 m), Bargibant's pygmy seahorse is so adept at mimicry that it was only discovered by chance in the late 1960s, when a laboratory researcher examining a gorgonian—a piece of soft, fanlike coral—realized that this tiny fish was attached to it. In addition to their much shorter, flattened snouts, pygmy seahorses differ from larger seahorse species in that the male's downward-facing brood pouch, in which he nurtures the fertilized eggs after mating, is located on his body cavity and not at the base of the tail. Their fleshier bodies lack easily distinguished segments, and they cling only to gorgonians, or sea fans, of the *Muricella* genus.

Little is known about the Bargibant's behavior, but like many other seahorse species, it anchors itself to corals with its prehensile tail, feeding on tiny crustaceans that float past.



↔ 1 in (2.5 cm)

👤 Not known

👤 Not known

🐛 Microscopic crustaceans



Indo-Pacific oceans

△ DENISE'S PYGMY SEAHORSE

At first believed to be a juvenile Bargibant's, Denise's pygmy seahorse (*H. denise*) is, at just 1/2 in (1.6 cm) in length, the smallest known seahorse species—and an equally effective camouflage artist.

▷ MASTER OF DISGUISE

Bargibant's pygmy seahorses are covered in wartlike tubercles that resemble the color and polyp texture of their host gorgonians so closely as to make them almost invisible.

